And despite Elderfield's offer of a second year, I felt no great security in my job. Elderfield was capable of fearsome acts on impulse. He had a graduate student named Chapin Smith who had been working on various problems of synthetic organic chemistry for three years without much success.

I had been working with him closely for some months and found him a thoughtful, intelligent fellow, but on January 6, 1949, he returned from a Christmas vacation and was greeted, quite suddenly and without warning, by the news that Elderfield was pitching him out on his ear.

Nor could I find any security in my writing. As I said, 1948 had been a disappointing year and though I was working on "—And Now You Don't," which had the potential of earning me a large check, I disliked it intensely and found working on it very difficult.

There was one minor note of success. My story "No Connection" had been picked up for anthologization in a collection to be called The Best Science Fiction Stories: 1949, and edited by Everett F. Bleiler and T. E. Dikty. It was the first time anyone ever planned a regular annual series of anthologies to include the best of the year. That brought in

$35-

As for books of my own, that seemed an utter will-o'-the-wisp. Although I had been told that Martin Greenberg would do "Grow Old with Me," the manuscript was back again. He had founded Gnome Press, but somehow nothing happened—at least not with me. At one point I seem to recall meeting him and discussing some changes, but it was all very lukewarm.

Fred Pohl told me that Doubleday was thinking of putting out a line of science-fiction books and he wondered whether they might be interested in "The Mule." I didn't mind having him check the matter and I gave him copies of Astounding that contained the story. Unfortunately, that came to nothing also.

I was at one of my low points as 1949 opened and it was clear that I had better start intensifying my search for a regular job. I could postpone it no longer.

Job Hunting

It was at this crucial moment of uncertainty that I received a phone call from Bill Boyd of Boston University School of Medicine on January 12, 1949. He